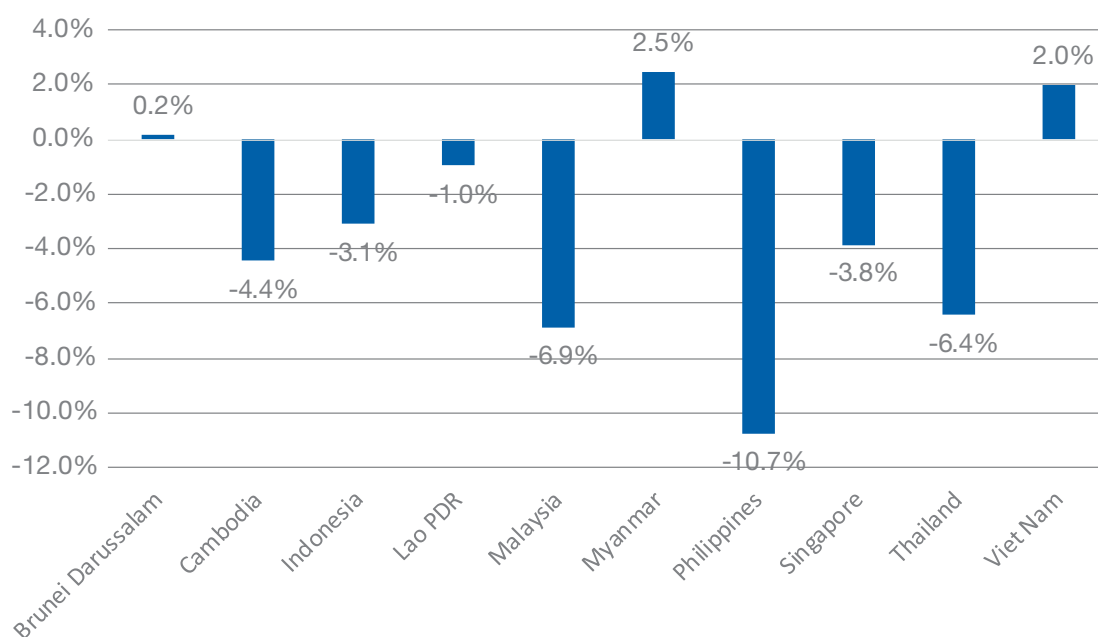


Thailand, Malaysia, and Singapore. In these three countries, per capita GDP fell between 4 percent to 7 percent.³

Figure 1.2. Per capita GDP growth in 2020



Source: World Bank (2022a)

It is also noteworthy that in two of these major destination countries – Thailand and Malaysia – the most-affected sectors were also ones heavily reliant on migrant workers. In Thailand, affected sectors include manufacturing, construction, agriculture, fishing, seafood processing, domestic work, and hospitality (United Nations Thematic Working Group, 2019; ILO, 2020). In Malaysia, migrant workers were, in 2019, especially prevalent in manufacturing (705,000), construction (435,000), services (306,000), plantation (282,000), agriculture (160,000), and domestic work (127,000) (Wahab, 2020a; Theng, Noor and Khalidi, 2020).

The construction sector in Malaysia crashed in the second quarter of 2020 and did not experience growth again until the second quarter of 2021, before suffering negative growth again the next quarter after a COVID-19 resurgence. Accommodation and dining establishments which includes many tourism-related jobs, fared even worse. Furthermore, wholesale trade and related activities in Malaysia have not recovered to pre-pandemic levels, even after growing in the first two quarters of 2021. In Thailand, the construction sector avoided a massive output decline similar to Malaysia's, although it did decline in the first quarter of 2020. However, manufacturing, accommodation, and wholesale trade in Thailand all suffered large contractions due to travel restrictions, supply chain disruptions, and weak aggregate demand, and, despite some recovery in the second quarter of 2021, remain well below pre-pandemic levels (Table 1.1).

³ The Philippine economy was hit hardest because of the length and severity of the movement restrictions imposed in the country (Olanday and Rigby, 2020).